A GAME BY GUILLAUME ENGUEHARD

TSUGI

Rules



Sixteen pieces on the table.
One group.
Seven to connect.

2 PLAYERS · NO BOARD

OVERVIEW

Sixteen pieces, one group

Tsugi is played without a board, with sixteen pieces laid on the table. Taking turns, each player slides one of their pieces over the others. The first to connect seven of their eight pieces wins. But all sixteen pieces must always stay together, and a piece hemmed in on every side can no longer move: every move helps as much as it hinders.

COMPONENTS

8 white pieces, 8 black pieces

All square and the same size. No board: you play on the table, as if on an invisible grid of squares stretching in every direction.



GOAL

Two ways to win

1. **Connect 7 of your 8 pieces** into one group touching side to side.
2. **Block your opponent:** a player who has no legal move on their turn loses at once.

The name: *tsugi* means "joint" in Japanese, the piece that links two others.



SETUP

1 A checkered square

1. Form a 4 × 4 square of pieces with alternating colours, like a checkerboard.
2. Seen from either player's side, the top-left corner is white.
3. White moves first, then the players take turns.

YOUR TURN

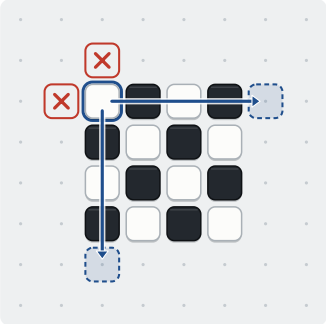
Slide a piece

On your turn you must move one of your pieces. There is a single movement rule, and four rules that say when a move is forbidden.

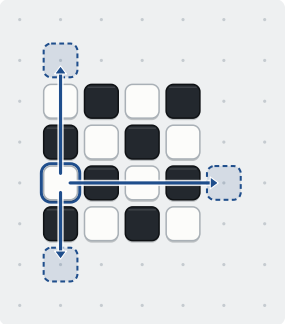
2 Movement

Slide one of your pieces horizontally or vertically towards a neighbouring piece. It passes over the whole continuous line of pieces that follows, whatever their colour, and stops on the first empty square.

A piece therefore always jumps at least one piece: it never slides into an adjacent empty square. Nothing is ever captured.



The corner piece can go east or south. Not north or west: there is no piece to jump.



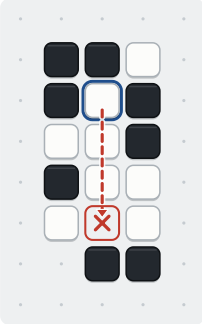
This white piece can go north, east or south.

3 Enclosed pieces

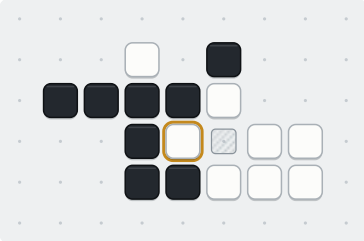
A piece whose four sides are occupied cannot move. An empty side that is a desert (rule 4) counts as occupied.



At the start, the two central white pieces are enclosed.



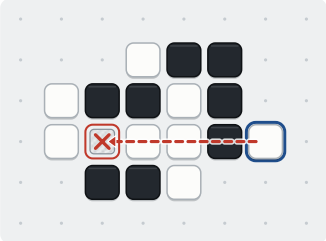
This piece would win by sliding south, but it is enclosed.



The circled piece has an empty square to the east, but it is a desert.

4 Deserts

An empty square whose four sides are occupied is a desert. No piece may stop there.

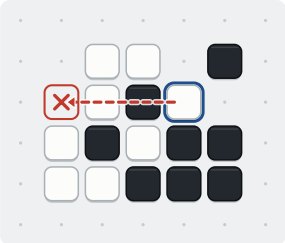


This slide would connect 7 white pieces, but the landing square (hatched) is a desert: forbidden.

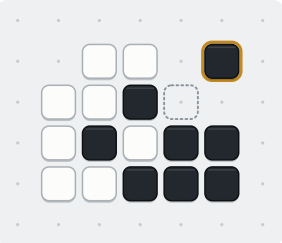
5 One group

After every move, all 16 pieces must form a single group: each piece touches the rest, step by step, by a side or a corner.

A move that would split this group is forbidden, even if it would win the game.



This slide would connect 7 white pieces...

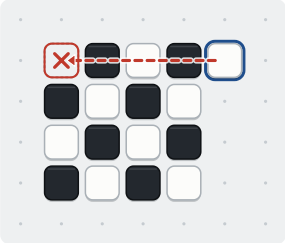


...but the circled black piece would be cut off from the rest: forbidden.

6 No going back

On your next turn, the piece you just moved cannot return to the square it just left.

All other pieces move freely. This rule prevents endless back-and-forth.



White has just moved the corner piece east. Next turn, this piece cannot return to the corner (dotted).

END OF THE GAME

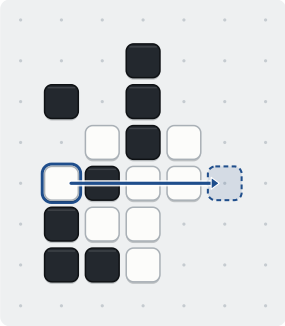
Connect, block or draw

The game ends as soon as a player connects seven pieces, as soon as a player cannot move, or in a draw.

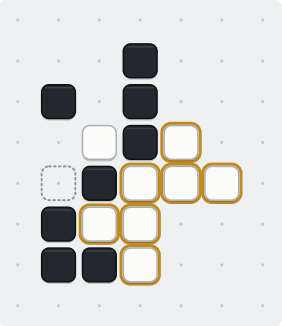
7 Victory

You win as soon as 7 of your 8 pieces form a group connected side to side.

Touching at a corner does not count. The eighth piece may be anywhere.



White slides this piece east, over three pieces.

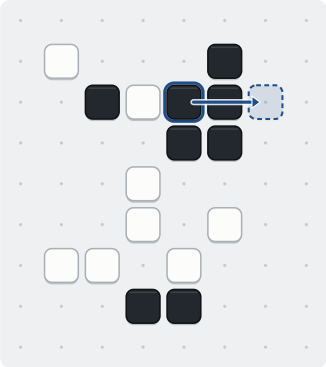


7 white pieces touch side to side: White wins.

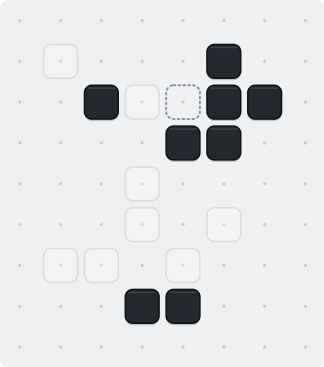
8 Blocked

A player who has no legal move on their turn loses immediately.

You never pass.



Black slides this piece east.



No white piece can move: each slide would split the group, end on a desert, or has nothing to jump. White loses.

9 Draw

If the same position occurs for the third time, with the same player to move, the game is a draw.

On their turn, a player may also offer a draw. If the opponent accepts, the game is drawn.

READING THE DIAGRAMS

- piece to move
- possible landing square
- forbidden move
- highlighted pieces
- square the last piece moved has just left
- desert

GLOSSARY

Connected	Two pieces of the same colour sharing a side. It is the only link that counts for victory.
Group	For rule 5: all pieces, of both colours, touching step by step by a side or a corner.
Enclosed	A piece whose four sides are occupied or face a desert.
Desert	An empty square enclosed on all four sides.
Move	One player's turn (a “ply”).

QUICK REFERENCE

The rules at a glance

1. **Start.** 4 × 4 checkered square, top-left corner white. White moves first.
2. **Slide.** One of your pieces slides in a straight line over a continuous line of pieces and stops on the first empty square.
3. **Enclosed.** A piece closed in on all four sides cannot move.
4. **Desert.** Never stop on an empty square enclosed on all four sides.
5. **One group.** After every move, all 16 pieces touch, by sides or corners.
6. **No going back.** The piece you just moved may not return, on your next turn, to the square it just left.
7. **Victory.** 7 of your pieces connected side to side.
8. **Blocked.** If you cannot move, you lose.
9. **Draw.** Same position three times, or a draw offer accepted.

GOING FURTHER

The *Tactics and strategy* booklet covers the ways to win and to defend, the combinations, and the principles that make the difference.

Tsugi · a game by Guillaume Enguehard

2 players · 16 pieces · no board